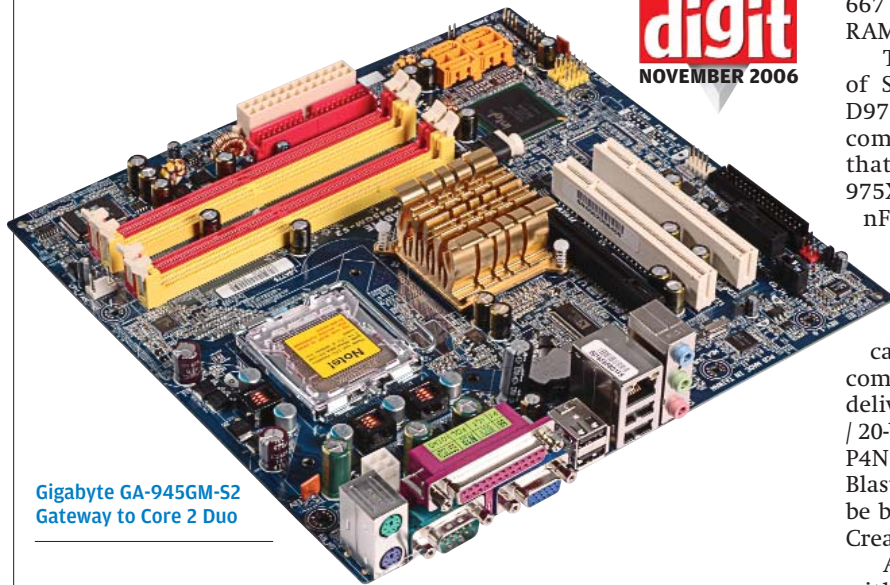


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NOVEMBER 2006



Gigabyte GA-945GM-S2
Gateway to Core 2 Duo

instead of spending around Rs 12,000 on a G965-based board, it might make sense to invest in the ASRock Conroe 945G-DVI.

As this segment is defined by value for money, the ECS 945G-M3 was the favourite, with a price tag of just Rs 4,395. But given its support for Core 2 Duos, the ASRock 945G-DVI takes the cake with a price tag of just Rs 4,500. On the other hand, MSI's 945G Platinum is really highly priced at Rs 8,000.

Keeping our focus on value for money and trying to squeeze in as much performance as we could, we decided that the ASRock Conroe 945G-DVI should be the Digit Best Buy Gold winner. Gigabyte's GA-945GM-S2 took the Digit Best Buy Silver. Both these boards are priced competitively and support the Core 2 Duos.

975X and nForce 4 SLI

This category is targeted at those who need just one thing—performance! Boards in this segment are targeted at gamers, enthusiasts, and audio/video editing professionals.

Features

We received four boards for this category from Intel and MSI, two each based on each chipset as well.

As we've already said, revisions to the 975X allow it to be used with Core 2 Duos. nForce 4 SLI-based motherboards are beaten here because they only support Pentium 4 EE/HT and Pentium D processors.

Both are older chipsets, and were designed for Pentium 4 and Pentium D processors. Also, both offer multi-GPU support. That's where the similarities end.

While the 975X series supports ATI's CrossFire solution, the nForce 4 SLI is built for NVIDIA's SLI multi-GPU solution. On paper, both chipsets can support DDR2 @ 667 MHz. However, we discovered that the 975X can also support DDR2 @ 800 MHz. So although the nForce 4 SLI can support up to 16 GB of RAM at

667 MHz, the 975X can support up to 8 GB of RAM at higher frequencies.

These boards can support a large number of SATA II drives, the top being the Intel D975XBX with support for up to eight. A common feature across all these boards is that all of them have support for RAID. While 975X chipsets use Intel's Matrix storage, nForce4 SLI boards utilise NVIDIA's NV RAID technology that spans across SATA and IDE hard drives.

All these motherboards supported HD audio for eight channels—called Azalia—at 192 KHz / 32-bit quality, compared to the earlier AC'97 standard that delivered a maximum of six channels at 48 KHz / 20-bit. The best audio solution was on the MSI P4N Diamond in the form of Creative SoundBlaster Live! 24-bit audio. This solution can only be beaten by an external audio solution like a Creative Audigy or X-Fi.

All the boards feature Gigabit LAN support, with P4N SLI and P4N Diamond supporting dual LAN. To keep the system fully updated, MSI boards feature "Live Update 3": this tool checks online for BIOS / drivers / utility updates. You can decide whether to proceed with the update(s) or not.

These boards have tremendous power but they're not really future-proof, especially with quad-core processors on the horizon.

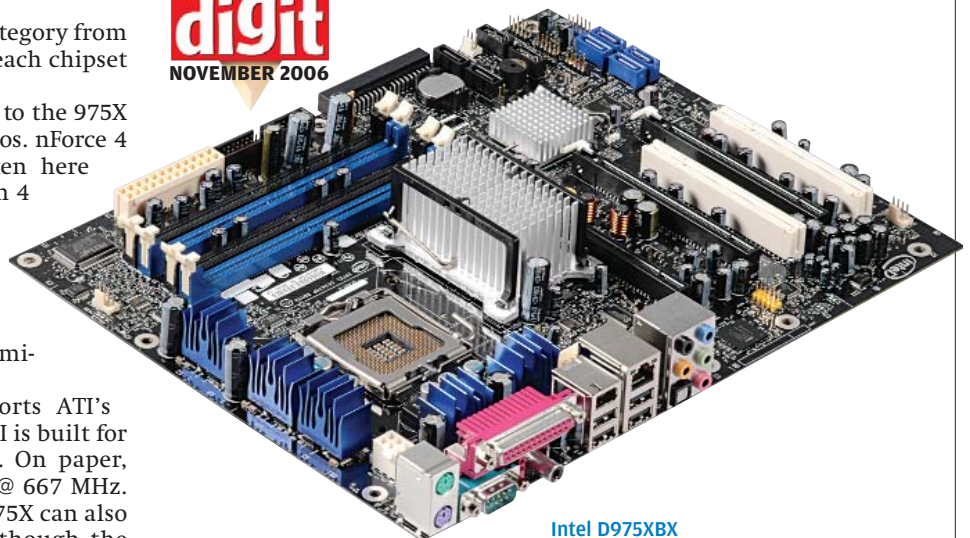
Performance

Gaming

The Intel D975XBX was the clear winner in this segment. It left its closest competitor, the MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition, lagging behind in *Far Cry*, though the difference in *Doom 3* was just around 5 fps. The MSI P4N SLI and the P4N Diamond were nowhere near the 975X boards.

The Intel D975XBX is definitely the board you should be looking at if you are an avid gamer, given that the price difference between the Intel D975XBX and the MSI 975X Platinum Power Up Edition is hardly anything.

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Intel D975XBX
A stable performer